Q+A

GIRL Next DOOR

IN HER LATEST OTT FILM ***KATHAL***, SANYA MALHOTRA DEMONSTRATES HER TALENT FOR PLAYING RELATABLE CHARACTERS



Q. You seem to have a liking for the small-town young woman, be it *Pataakha* or *Pagglait*. What was your approach to playing Mahima, the police officer in *Kathal*?

My conditioning since my debut film, *Dangal*, has been that without homework, *set pe naa jaaiye, naak kat jaayegi* [Go to set well-prepared or risk being embarrassed]. I've never been around police officers. Through *Kathal*, I got to spend time with female officers in Gwalior. One of them said, '*Hum auratein hain joh aaram se sun paati hain*' [We're good listeners]. After meeting her, I felt Mahima could be feminine, empathetic and have a gentle quality to her.

Q. This is your fourth Netflix film. Is it hard to say no to Netflix, and more so to Guneet Monga, who also produced *Pagglait*?

She understands what I like. I didn't want to do *Pagglait* because I didn't have the confidence to shoulder a film. But she changed my mind. I saw how well it was received.... She was excited for *Kathal* and I felt if she is excited, then I must trust her. She has a good script sense. We all know that. She has an Oscar.

Q. What do you think OTT has given you as an actor?

A lot of freedom to experiment with the kind of roles I am doing and the scripts I can pick. Not only actors but a lot of people in the industry also feel that now. I have seen a major change in my career and have access to a way bigger audience.

Q. Do you think 2023 is a seminal year for you with films like *Jawan* and *Sam Bahadur*?

Definitely. I shot five films back-to-back in 2022. I was jumping from one set to another.... I was doing so much work, but I couldn't see any of them coming out and judge where my career was going. This year is about sitting back and watching what works for me. *Mrs.* [a remake of *The Great Indian Kitchen*] is completely different from *Sam*. *Jawan* is another ballgame altogether. It is a big one for me.

with Suhani Singh

Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH